KRISTY KIM

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EDUCATION	DEGREE	DATE	FIELD
University of California, Berkeley	**Ph.D.**	2019 - 2025	**Economics**

NSF Graduate Research Fellowships Program ($145,000),
Center for Retirement Research at Boston College Dissertation Fellow ($28,000)
Certificate in Teaching and Learning in Higher Education
Dissertation Title: "Three Essays in Public Economics: Labor, Capital, and Welfare"
Principal Advisor: Professor Emmanuel Saez

University of California, Berkeley	**B.A.**	2013 - 2016	**Economics**

Highest Distinction in General Scholarship and Highest Honors in Economics (equiv. summa cum laude)

RESEARCH

"**From Pensions to Personnel: The Incentive Effects of Retirement Benefits on Retention**"

With Caleb Wroblewski

Abstract: *Private retirement plans are a crucial component of worker's compensation in the U.S. and have long been thought to influence labor supply. This study uses a cohort-based regression discontinuity design to examine how a change in the retirement plan at the largest U.S. employer, the federal government, impacted the retention of employees over their full career. Workers with less valuable employer pensions but more portable retirement benefits were more likely to separate from the government between 15 and 30 years after beginning federal service. These effects are driven by highly productive workers, identified through supplemental compensation or early promotions, and workers with better outside options. These findings demonstrate that nonwage compensation impacts labor supply decisions across a worker's lifecycle and the distribution of human capital over time, particularly in labor markets where employers compete through diverse compensation structures.*

"**Welfare and the Act of Choosing**" (Accepted at the *Journal of Political Economy*)

With B. Douglas Bernheim and Dmitry Taubinsky

Abstract: *The standard revealed-preference approach to welfare economics encounters fundamental difficulties when the act of choosing directly affects welfare through emotions such as guilt, pride, and anxiety. New survey evidence highlights the relevance of these difficulties for consequential decisions. Our solution involves a new approach that assumes preferences pertain to the bundles of sensations decisions produce. We measure those preferences by blending data on choices and subjective sensations. Implementation of our approach in an experiment on redistributive preferences confirms that standard welfare methods involving revealed-preference, including those that exploit choices over menus, mismeasure welfare, as do alternatives involving subjective well-being.*

"**Behavioral Responses to Taxation of Inherited Property**"

With Sarah Baker and Siddhartha Biswas

Abstract: *Whether inheritance taxation reduces wealth inequality and raises tax revenue hinges on households' behavioral responses. We examine responses to California's Proposition 19, which eliminated property tax benefits for most inherited homes. Using data from San Francisco and Los Angeles counties, we find that households accelerated inter-vivos property transfers to their children by 13 to 18 months, timing transfers to occur between the policy's announcement and implementation. This response is concentrated among wealthy, white households with higher-value homes, undermining the policy's redistributive and revenue-generating objectives. We also find that properties transferred immediately before implementation are less likely to be sold within four years, consistent with our theoretical framework predicting that accelerating transfers is most beneficial when heirs hold properties longer. Finally, we estimate that accelerated transfers resulted in tax revenue losses of $1.7 to $2.1 billion in Los Angeles and San Francisco alone.*

Ongoing: The impact of defined benefit to defined contribution benefits on retirement security; Vacancy chains and asymmetric adjustment in the public sector

EXPERIENCE

Applied Economist | Congressional Budget Office 2025 - Present

Skills and Tools: *Python, Stata, SQL, forecasting/prediction, ML, microsimulation, policy memos*

- Forecast the effects of current credit policies on federal student loan outlays over ten years for Congress, using the Department of Ed's borrower micro-data to project borrower behavior in a Python microsimulation; model borrower repayment-plan choice with ML and structural estimation, improving predictive accuracy by 27% relative to baseline. Contributed to the 2026-2036 Budget and Economic Outlook.
- Develop forecasting methods to capture U.S. investment spending in data centers and semiconductors, using macroeconomic models, trade data, and public/private leads.
- Conduct ongoing empirical research on retirement security, AI policy in the public sector, and federal personnel trends.

PhD Student, Researcher, and Graduate Instructor | UC Berkeley 2019 - 2025

Skills and Tools: *Stata, Python, R, Javascript, Qualtrics/Prolific/MTurk, causal inference, survey design, academic presentations*

- Estimated the causal effect of workplace retirement benefits on retention using 100k-worker, 30-year administrative panel; applied regression discontinuity, event study designs, and bunching estimators. Built ML-assisted record-linkage pipeline across government and private data sources; validated match quality and improved coverage of the panel.
- Led end-to-end research process from research design to journal submission to a top-ranked economics journal.
- Guided students across varying skill levels through the intuition of machine learning and causal inference methods (e.g., regularization, random forests, RCTs), using R for data analysis.

Research Professional | Booth School of Business at UChicago 2017 - 2019

- Cleaned and analyzed large datasets, including granular geospatial mobility data, nationwide medical insurance claims, and online secondary marketplace data, for policy evaluation and causal inference.
- Conducted a large-scale audit study; automated web scraping and dispatching of 100,000+ emails via a custom API.
- Asterisk projects: [Project 1] [Project 2] [Project 3]

Investment Funds Case Assistant for the Fund Formation Group | Cooley LLP 2016 - 2017

- Supported the fund formation of 11 international venture capital groups by preparing IRS/FINRA/SEC filings and ensuring regulatory compliance.

ACADEMIC SERVICE

✎ **Referee for** *The Review of Economic Studies* and the *Journal of Public Economics*

SELECTED SEMINAR AND CONFERENCES

2026 Washington Area Labor Economics Symposium

2025 National Bureau of Economic Research Summer Institute - Economics of Social Security; Questrom School of Business at Boston University; Federal Reserve Bank in Philadelphia; Congressional Budget Office; Office of Tax Analysis at the U.S. Treasury, National Tax Association

2024 New Directions in the Study of Labor at the Social Science Matrix

TEACHING

Graduate Student Instructor, Department of Economics, UC Berkeley
MBA Data Analytics (MBA200A) - Fall 2023, Fall 2022
Intro to Economics (ECON2) - Spring 2023

Tutor, Department of Economics, UC Berkeley
Public Economics (ECON131) - Fall 2021
Intro to Economics (ECON1) - Spring 2020, Fall 2019

Reader, Department of Economics, UC Berkeley and Booth School of Business at the University of Chicago
Graduate Psychology and Economic Theory (ECON219A) - Fall 2021
MBA Consumer Behavior [37101] - Winter 2018